COUNTRY REPORTS: SOUTH AFRICA

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News, Sep – Oct 2026

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies · Legislation and regulation · Data protection · Regional collaboration · Public debate and participation in policymaking

Strategies, plans and policies

REGULATOR INQUIRY INTO OVER-THE-TOP SERVICES

- **Notice of intention to conduct market inquiry into the impact of over-the-top (OTT) services on licensees and regulatory framework in South Africa - Notice 4129 of 2026** — Independent Communications Authority of South Africa (Government Gazette No. 55299), 4 September 2026

  South Africa's communications regulator, ICASA, gazetted notice of a market inquiry into the impact of over-the-top services on telecoms, broadcasting and postal licensees on 4 September 2026. The inquiry has four phases: a questionnaire with 45 working days for responses, a discussion document for comment, possible public hearings, and findings gazetted within 90 days of its conclusion.

- **OTT prices in line of fire: Icasa takes aim at Netflix and WhatsApp** — Sunday Times (TimesLIVE), 7 September 2026

  South Africa's communications regulator said it will inquire into the effect of over-the-top services on consumers, against licensed broadcasters losing audience and revenue.

- **South Africa's industry regulator launches market inquiries into OTT services and telecom affordability** — Broadcast Media Africa, 9 September 2026

  South Africa's communications regulator ICASA launched two market inquiries, one into the effect of over-the-top services such as Netflix and WhatsApp on its telecoms, broadcasting and postal licensees, the other into telecoms affordability. Each runs in four phases, with 45 working days for written responses; findings will be published in the Government Gazette. No new charge on platforms has been announced.

NATIONAL AI POLICY

- **AI governance cannot wait for policy** — ITWeb Africa, 18 September 2026

  An opinion piece by the lead of Lefa AI argues that South African schools need AI safeguards now. It cites the 2024 TALIS survey, in which 48% of South African lower-secondary teachers had used AI against an OECD average of 36%, and a January 2026 FEDSAS survey of 99 Eastern Cape educators in which only 4% said their school had an AI policy.

- **AI policy gets a second chance** — Business Times (BusinessDay), 3 October 2026

South Africa's deputy communications minister, Mondli Gungubele, said the redrafted national AI policy goes to the minister before the end of November 2026 and to cabinet by the end of the 2026/27 financial year. The earlier draft, released this year, was withdrawn after it was found to contain AI-generated, invented citations.

- **Malatsi wants South Africa's AI policy back on track after false start** — TechCabal, 15 October 2026

  One of the two South African officials suspended over the draft national AI policy that cited invented sources has resigned, and disciplinary proceedings continue against the other. The communications minister said cabinet will finalise a replacement before the end of March 2027, with public consultation expected from April.

DISCUSSION DOCUMENT ON SUBSIDIES FOR NEEDY PERSONS

- **Discussion Document on Categories of Needy Persons and Subsidy Application and Payment Modalities (with General Notice inviting comments)** — Universal Service and Access Agency of South Africa (USAASA), 30 September 2026

  South Africa's Universal Service and Access Agency published a discussion document on 30 September 2026 on which needy persons should receive electronic communications subsidies, who must apply and who may be paid. It sets six provisional propositions with financial inability as the central test, but proposes no income threshold, benefit amount or payment platform. Comments close on 30 October 2026.

- **Who qualifies as a 'needy person'? — Usaasa weighs new digital subsidy rules** — TimesLIVE (Sunday Times), 10 October 2026

  The Universal Service and Access Agency of South Africa has invited public comment on a discussion document on who should qualify as a 'needy person' for subsidised access to communications services, who should apply and how subsidies should be paid, reported on 10 October 2026. The consultation, under section 88 of the Electronic Communications Act, sets no income threshold. No comment deadline is given.

REGULATOR INQUIRY INTO THE IMPACT OF OVER-THE-TOP SERVICES

- **Government Gazette No. 55476 (30 September 2026): ICASA General Notice 4180 of 2026, withdrawal of Notice 4130 (affordability inquiry), and withdrawal of Notices 4129 and 4148 (OTT inquiry)** — Independent Communications Authority of South Africa (ICASA), Government Gazette No. 55476, 30 September 2026

  South Africa's communications regulator ICASA withdrew its notice of an inquiry into the affordability of telecommunications services (Notice 4130 of 2026) in Government Gazette No. 55476 of 30 September 2026. The same gazette withdrew Notices 4129 and 4148 on an inquiry into over-the-top services, and reprinted a draft notice of intention to hold the affordability inquiry in four phases.

- **ICASA withdraws notices on OTT services and telecommunications affordability inquiries** — Independent Communications Authority of South Africa (ICASA), 1 October 2026

  South Africa's communications regulator, ICASA, withdrew on 1 October 2026 its notices launching inquiries into telecommunications affordability and the impact of over-the-top services, citing administrative and procedural matters. The affordability notice will be republished with a draft questionnaire and the OTT notice later; earlier submissions can be resubmitted.

REVIEW OF THE 2010 UNIVERSAL ACCESS AND UNIVERSAL SERVICE DETERMINATION

- **Government Notice 7985 (Gazette 55494): Invitation to comment on the Discussion Document on Universal Access and Universal Service** — Universal Service and Access Agency of South Africa (USAASA), Government Gazette No. 55494, 1 October 2026

The Universal Service and Access Agency of South Africa published a discussion document on universal access and universal service in the Government Gazette on 1 October 2026, reviewing the 2010 determination. It sets out three options and favours a targeted revision; comments close on 30 October 2026.

- **Public consultation to update universal digital access policy** — Sunday Times, 10 October 2026

  South Africa's universal service agency is consulting on whether to update the 2010 determination that defines universal access and universal service. Its discussion document sets out three options and leans towards a targeted revision; it creates no new funding or licence obligations.

UNIVERSAL SERVICE AND ACCESS FUND MANUAL

- **USAASA to implement approved USAF manual** — ITWeb South Africa, 5 October 2026

  South Africa's universal service agency says the communications minister has approved the manual for the Universal Service and Access Fund, setting its objectives, governance, funding instruments and accountability. An earlier draft was withdrawn in November 2025 and a revised one went out for comment in February 2026.

Legislation and regulation

NATIONAL PAYMENT SYSTEM BILL

- **National Payment System Bill: Sarb readies overhaul** — TechCentral, 1 September 2026

  South Africa's Reserve Bank governor said the National Payment System Bill will soon go out for public comment, moving payment regulation from an entity-based model to an activity-based one — the change that would open payment licensing beyond banks.

REGULATOR'S POWER TO CONDONE A LATE LICENCE RENEWAL

- **ICASA turns to ConCourt to clarify its powers** — ITWeb South Africa, 2 September 2026

  ICASA has asked the Constitutional Court to settle whether it may condone a late licence-renewal notice from a class licensee, having lost the question in both the Pretoria High Court and the Supreme Court of Appeal to Open Heaven, a Hammanskraal community radio station that filed two weeks late. The regulator reads section 11(9) of the Electronic Communications Act as granting that power only for individual licences, and section 19(2) as deliberately withholding it for class licences; Open Heaven argues the Act leaves latitude where good cause is shown. The court heard the matter on 27 August and has not ruled.

OPERATOR ASSOCIATION EXEMPTION TO SHARE INFRASTRUCTURE PLANNING DATA

- **SA telco giants seek competition waiver in rural broadband rollout** — Sunday Times (TimesLIVE), 5 September 2026

  South Africa's main telecoms operators, through the Association of Communications and Technology, have asked the competition authorities for an exemption to share limited planning information on passive infrastructure such as towers and ducts in rural and underserved areas. Coordination would run through an independent third party to split build costs. The association represents Vodacom, MTN, Telkom, Cell C, Liquid and Rain.

- **South Africa Pushes Subsea Cable, AI and Digital Skills Agenda to Expand Connectivity** — Tech Africa News, 8 September 2026

South Africa's operator association has asked the Competition Commission for a five-year exemption letting Vodacom, MTN, Telkom, Cell C, Rain and Liquid share limited infrastructure planning information through an independent third party, to find connectivity gaps and avoid duplicated build. The communications minister, who called the proposal encouraging for rural areas and townships, also argued that disruption to Middle East routes gives the country an opening as an alternative submarine cable hub.

ELECTORAL CODE OF CONDUCT ON COUNTERING DISINFORMATION

- **IEC gazettes code to tackle election disinformation** — ITWeb South Africa, 9 September 2026

  South Africa's Electoral Commission has gazetted a Disinformation Code for the local government elections on 4 November, binding political parties, candidates and anyone acting on their instruction or for reward across all election-related communication, online or offline, paid or unpaid. Parties and candidates must check information before sharing it, publicly retract and correct anything false within 36 hours of becoming aware of it, label AI-generated content and political advertising, and report online disinformation to Real411 within 36 hours; fake accounts, bot networks, coordinated inauthentic behaviour, doxing and cyberbullying are prohibited, as is disinformation targeting the commission or its staff. Contravention carries the sanctions applying to the Electoral Code of Conduct under the Municipal Electoral Act 27 of 2000, and parties will undertake to comply at the signing ceremony on 23 September; the source gives no gazette number or date for the final code.

POSITION ON AGE ASSURANCE FOR UNDER-16S

- **South Africa rejects blanket social media age verification for under-16s** — Biometric Update, 10 September 2026

  South Africa's communications minister told parliament the government is not pursuing any blanket policy restricting under-16s from social media, saying platforms should instead strengthen their own protections against harmful content. The position separates the country from a growing number of states, several of them African, adopting age-assurance requirements.

- **South Africa has no plan to ban under-16s from social media** — IOL, 16 September 2026

  South Africa's Department of Communications and Digital Technologies said on 16 September 2026 that it has no legislation planned to bar under-16s from social media. Minister Solly Malatsi said there is no clear evidence such bans keep children offline, and the department will instead strengthen the Film and Publication Board and NEMISA and build digital literacy. Parliament's portfolio committee is considering summoning the platforms over online harms.

FILM AND PUBLICATION BOARD ENFORCEMENT UNDER THE FILMS AND PUBLICATIONS ACT

- **Online content crackdown nets R16m in fines** — ITWeb South Africa, 17 September 2026

  South Africa's Film and Publication Board imposed R16.175 million in fines on distributors found non-compliant with the Films and Publications Act, most of the content distributed online. The board says its enforcement reaches distributors based abroad.

AMENDED COURT RULES FOR ACCESS-TO-INFORMATION APPLICATIONS

- **Media Statement: Justice Committee Approves Publication of Proposed Amended PAIA Court Rules to Enhance Transparency and Access to Justice** — Parliament of South Africa, 23 September 2026

South Africa's parliamentary justice committee agreed on 23 September 2026 that the Department of Justice may publish proposed amended court rules for applications under the Promotion of Access to Information Act. The draft rules standardise section 78 applications across all courts, require sworn section 80 representations five days before hearings, and repeal the previous PAIA rules. They are not yet in force.

NATIONAL IDENTIFICATION AND REGISTRATION BILL

- **Problem with plan for digital IDs in South Africa** — MyBroadband, 6 October 2026

  South Africa's Home Affairs missed its first-quarter target to sign a work order starting procurement of digital ID hosting infrastructure, its quarterly report to Parliament's committee says. It also missed revising the National Identification Registration Bill for public comment, and now aims to finalise the procurement in the second quarter.

Data protection

PROTECTION OF PERSONAL INFORMATION ACT AND INFORMATION REGULATOR

- **POPIA grace period limits regulator's fines** — ITWeb South Africa, 2 September 2026

  South Africa's Information Regulator called the compliance grace period the data protection Act's key weakness: a public body that remedies a violation within the stated timeframe cannot then be fined. Its chair said the high-value fines issued since enforcement powers commenced in July 2021 have largely not materialised, with bodies either complying in time or challenging in court.

- **InfoReg unpacks regulatory complexities posed by AI** — ITWeb South Africa, 17 September 2026

  South Africa's Information Regulator says artificial intelligence, automated decision-making and biometric systems have produced compliance questions its founding laws did not anticipate, naming consent, retention, transparency and the absence of a national artificial-intelligence policy. Its chairperson said the regulator is not convinced privacy by default or personal information impact assessments are being practised.

POLICE BODY-WORN CAMERAS WITH FACIAL RECOGNITION

- **SAPS wants to deploy AI bodycams with facial recognition** — TechCentral, 10 September 2026

  South African Police Service body-worn cameras must be able to conduct facial recognition, according to state IT agency tender documents. The requirement sits in the bid specification for a three-year contract covering body-worn and vehicle dashboard cameras and related software, and says the solution must also integrate with various security platforms; bids close on 29 September.

CONSUMER PROTECTION ACT DIRECT-MARKETING OPT-OUT REGISTRY

- **Commission seeks tech partners to block spam calls** — Sunday Times, 12 September 2026

  South Africa's National Consumer Commission issued a request for proposals for service providers to support its national opt-out registry for direct marketing, which it wants live in 2026, reported on 12 September 2026. Under amended consumer protection rules, marketers must register and check their lists against the registry, and face fines of up to R1 million or 10 per cent of turnover.

- **Guidelines for Compliance with Opt-Out Registry Regulations [Draft] (GN 7981)** — National Consumer Commission (South Africa), 2 October 2026

  South Africa's National Consumer Commission published draft guidelines on compliance with the opt-out registry regulations on 2 October 2026 (GN 7981), inviting comment within 15 days. Every direct marketer must register on the registry, renew annually and check its contact list against it each month it markets, at 12 cents per blocked entry.

- **National Consumer Commission launches National Opt-Out Registry** — South African Government, 7 October 2026

  South Africa's National Consumer Commission launched the National Opt-Out Registry on 7 October 2026, letting consumers block unwanted direct-marketing calls, SMSes and other messages free of charge. Direct marketers must register by December 2026 and may cleanse their lists free until April 2027; consumers can register blocks from May 2027.

Regional collaboration

REGIONAL HIGHER EDUCATION DATA SYSTEM (SADC)

- **SADC must build its own knowledge to drive industrialisation, says Manamela** — SAnews (South African Government News Agency), 1 September 2026 SOUTHERN AFRICA

  South Africa's higher education minister, Buti Manamela, told a meeting of SADC university vice-chancellors in Johannesburg on 31 August 2026 that the region must build its own computing capacity, datasets, African-language technologies and cybersecurity. He set five priorities, including agreement on a regional higher education data system, to show results by the SADC ministers' meeting in June 2027.

- **Universities should turn regional cooperation into action** — University of the Witwatersrand, 1 September 2026 SOUTHERN AFRICA

  University leaders, government representatives, the SADC Secretariat and the Southern African Regional Universities Association met at Wits University on 31 August–1 September 2026. They discussed the SADC higher education strategy, a proposed SADC University of Transformation, a regional higher education data system and micro-credentials. No design, cost or timetable for the data system is given.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

HARMFUL ONLINE CONTENT GOVERNANCE REVIEW

- **When harm goes viral: Multistakeholder forum launches timely report on South Africa's social media problem** — Research ICT Africa, 18 September 2026

  Research ICT Africa, the Centre for Analytics and Behavioural Change and Moxii Africa launched a study in Johannesburg on 17 September 2026 finding that South Africa's laws on harmful online content are adequate but enforcement is fragmented. It found platform moderation in English alone leaves out 10 of 11 official languages, and that cases of harassment, doxxing and deepfakes can take up to seven years to resolve. The study was EU-funded.

Finance

Domestic budget appropriations and expenditure · New investments

Domestic budget appropriations and expenditure

UNIVERSAL SERVICE AND ACCESS FUND COLLECTIONS AND UNSPENT BALANCE

- **Minister of Communications and Digital Technologies - reply to National Assembly oral question 763 (Hlazo-Webster): USAF collections and unspent funds** — Department of Communications and Digital Technologies (via Parliamentary Monitoring Group), 30 September 2026

  South Africa's communications minister told the National Assembly, in an oral reply approved on 30 September 2026, that ICASA collected R1,287,583,749 for the Universal Service and Access Fund over the five years to 2025/26, with about R652 million left unspent at the end of 2025/26. He cited delays in set-top-box installation and broadband projects; 2025/26 spending included a R567 million write-off of digital-migration stock.

- **Here's how much government collected towards digital migration in the last five years** — The Citizen, 5 October 2026

  South Africa's communications minister told Parliament that about R1.29 billion was collected for the Universal Service and Access Fund over five years and about R652 million was unspent at the end of 2025/26. Spending that year included a R567 million write-off of set-top-box inventory, and there is still no analogue switch-off date.

New investments

GLOBAL BUSINESS SERVICES CENTRE INVESTMENT (CAPE TOWN)

- **SA's global business services presents opportunities for economic growth** — SAnews.gov.za, 1 September 2026

  Atain, a company selling AI-driven customer experience and business process services, opened a R70 million global business services centre in Cape Town that will take its South African workforce from about 1,500 to 2,100. South Africa's deputy trade minister John Steenhuisen spoke at the opening. No date for the investment decision is given.

COMPLIANCE PLATFORM INVESTMENT (INSTARC)

- **Instarc Secures EUR1.25 Million to Scale Cloud-Native Compliance Platform in South Africa** — Tech Africa News, 2 September 2026

  Instarc, a Tallinn-based regulatory-technology firm, raised a €1.25 million strategic investment from HFO Investments to commercialise its compliance platform for South African accountable institutions under the Financial Intelligence Centre Act. The platform covers client onboarding, identity and ownership verification, configurable workflows, document management, retrievable audit records and APIs into existing systems, and the company says it is built to adapt to other regulatory regimes. The date the investment was agreed is not stated in the reporting held.

RECAPITALISATION OF THE VIVICA FIBRE AND TELECOMS GROUP

- **SA investment firm ploughs R2.1bn into digital economy** — ITWeb South Africa, 14 September 2026

  South African investment firm DNI announced more than R2.1 billion across Frogfoot, Vox and Hypa, Mission Mobile and KnowRoaming. Its consortium holds 34.8% of Frogfoot and Vox at an aggregate R14.4 billion valuation, with Frogfoot's capital aimed at 360,000 lower-income homes over 12 months.

- **Proparco invests US$20 million in Frogfoot, Vox and Hypa to expand affordable fibre connectivity in South Africa** — Proparco, 5 October 2026

  Proparco, the French development finance institution, said on 5 October 2026 that it is investing US$20 million in South African fibre and connectivity companies Frogfoot, Vox and Hypa, in a consortium led by Metier with BII, BIO, DEG, Ke Nako Capital, Nedbank and Standard Bank. The funds are for extending fibre into lower-income and township areas. No signing date is given.

UNITED STATES DEVELOPMENT FINANCE EQUITY IN A JOHANNESBURG-HEADQUARTERED OPERATOR

- **US govt agency pouring billions into African digital infrastructure firm with HQ in Joburg** — EWN (Eyewitness News), 17 September 2026

> The United States development finance corporation approved an equity investment in a Johannesburg-headquartered operator of undersea cables, fibre networks and data centres in more than 30 African countries, naming two investment partners. Its board published no amount; a news organisation puts the investment at around R2.5 billion, up to US$155 million, as a ceiling rather than a committed sum.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity · Data Storage · Energy · Technical Capacity · Cybersecurity

Connectivity

RÉUNION TO SOUTH AFRICA SUBMARINE CABLE

- **"RéuNION" : bientôt un nouveau câble sous-marin entre La Réunion et l'Afrique du Sud** — Outre-mer La 1ère (France Télévisions), 2 September 2026

  The Réunion regional authority launched RéuNION, a submarine cable from Saint-Paul to Durban costing €93.1 million and carrying 16 fibre pairs at 20 Tbps each. It is funded by €30m from the EU's regional development fund, €20m from the Connecting Europe Facility and €43.1m from the consortium, and must be built within three years under the European funding terms.

- **[vidéo] Un nouveau câble sous-marin en 2028** — Le Quotidien de La Réunion, 2 September 2026

  The Réunion to South Africa cable is scheduled to enter service in 2028, adding route diversity before an older system retires from 2027. Marine surveys run in 2026, with manufacture and laying to follow.

- **Free investit massivement dans un câble sous-marin pour sécuriser la connexion de La Réunion** — Univers Freebox, 2 September 2026

  A French operator set out its investment in the Réunion to South Africa cable, one of four consortium members behind a system carrying 16 fibre pairs at 20 Tbps each. The consortium is wholly French and about 79 per cent of the cost rests on public bodies.

- **Orange and Free to back La Reunion-South Africa subsea cable** — CNBC Africa (Reuters), 2 September 2026

  Two French operators will fund the €93 million cable between Réunion and South Africa, one acting as landing party and its marine subsidiary laying infrastructure designed by a French manufacturer. The cable is scheduled to enter service in 2028, replacing a system commissioned in 2002; the partners did not disclose their respective shares.

- **Free investit dans l'avenir numerique de La Reunion avec le projet de cable sous-marin ReuNION** — DCmag, 9 September 2026

  Free, through Telco OI, joined the EUR93 million ReuNION consortium led by La Reunion Connectee to build a submarine cable linking La Reunion directly to South Africa. The 16-fibre-pair system is planned for service in 2028 as successor to SAFE, in service since 2002 and at end of life.

DIGITAL CONNECTIVITY INVESTMENT ROADMAP TO 2035

- **South Africa's Digital Connectivity Investment Roadmap to 2035 (Digital Infrastructure Investment Study)** — Development Bank of Southern Africa (DBSA) / National Planning Commission (NPC), 30 March 2026

  A study by the DBSA and the National Planning Commission estimates that universal high-speed broadband in South Africa will need R108bn to R142bn of additional investment by 2035, in 2025 terms. An annex surveys the data-centre market, which it puts at nearly 500MW of potential IT load, concentrated in Gauteng.

THIRD NATIONAL FIBRE ROUTE, CAPE TOWN TO PRETORIA

- **Openserve completes third fibre route to reduce network outage risk** — BusinessDay South Africa, 7 September 2026

  The state-affiliated wholesale operator completed a third long-haul fibre route from Cape Town to Pretoria via Springbok and Mahikeng, built so the network stays up through major breaks. It sits inside a wholesale network of about 180,000km carrying just under R3bn of capital expenditure a year.

STATE SIGNAL DISTRIBUTOR FINANCIAL POSITION

- **Sentech trims losses but remains in the red** — ITWeb South Africa, 10 September 2026

  South Africa's state signal distributor cut its net loss after tax to R60 million in 2025/26 from R246 million, an improvement of about 76 per cent, and reported a clean audit with no material findings. The previous year's loss was driven mainly by a provision for expected credit loss reflecting customers' economic difficulties.

EQUINIX CAPE TOWN LAND USE

- **Activists appeal Cape Town data centre approval** — GroundUp, 14 September 2026

  The Housing Assembly and Foxglove, represented by the Legal Resources Centre, appealed the City of Cape Town's 14 July rezoning approval for an Equinix hyperscale data centre at King Air Industria, GroundUp reported on 14 September 2026. They say nearby communities were not consulted and that the application lacked information on water, electricity, emissions and noise for the proposed 174 MVA facility. Equinix has not yet submitted a site plan.

- **Cape Town to write new rules for big data centre applications** — TechCentral, 17 September 2026

  Cape Town is drafting new development guidelines for large data-centre applications, its first public acknowledgement that the approvals process needs changing, and confirms that the hyperscale precinct rezoning it granted in July is suspended pending appeal. The operator named throughout the project says the site is a long-term land bank on which it has submitted no planning application.

- **Big Tech or public good? What Cape Town's data centre battle means for residents** — Daily Maverick, 12 October 2026

  One of the organisations appealing against land-use rights for a planned hyperscale data centre in Cape Town argues that the mayor should uphold the appeal because the application did not state the site's water use, emissions or jobs. It writes that the appeal went before the city's advisory panel on 12 October and that the mayor then has 90 days to decide.

SUSTAINABLE CONNECTIVITY AND COMMUNITY-LED DIGITAL ECONOMIES IN SOUTH AFRICA PROJECT

- **WOAN comeback in KZN with R7m UK funding** — ITWeb South Africa, 15 September 2026

  A R7m UK-funded programme in KwaZulu-Natal, run with South Africa's communications department, will support 25 local community network operators to deploy 250 public Wi-Fi hotspots, connect 150 schools, libraries and clinics and reach 1,500 homes. It applies the shared wireless open-access model locally after the national version was put on hold; no term or completion date is given.

GAUTENG SMART SCHOOLS PROGRAMME

- **Gauteng Legislature visits facilities on SMART Schools Programme** — Gauteng Provincial Legislature (gov.za), 16 September 2026

The Gauteng Provincial Legislature's e-Government and Research Development committee, chaired by Mbali Hlophe, announced oversight visits to schools under the province's SMART Schools Programme from 17 September 2026, starting at Moshate Secondary in Sedibeng and Johannesburg School. It will examine network reliability, delays in ICT infrastructure, incomplete connectivity, underfunding and reliance on temporary connections.

POLICY DIRECTION RESERVING HIGH-DEMAND SPECTRUM FOR A WIRELESS OPEN ACCESS NETWORK (2019)

- **Wireless open access network licensing direction withdrawn** — ITWeb South Africa, 28 September 2026

  South Africa withdrew the 2019 policy reserving high-demand spectrum for a wireless open access network that was never licensed, freeing it for the regulator to assign. Wholesale, universal-service and anti-concentration obligations on licensees stay, as does the 2024 set-aside for the state digital infrastructure company.

ANALOGUE TELEVISION SWITCH-OFF DATE

- **Minister of Communications and Digital Technologies - reply to National Assembly oral question 763 (Hlazo-Webster): USAF collections and unspent funds** — Department of Communications and Digital Technologies (via Parliamentary Monitoring Group), 30 September 2026

  Summarised under Domestic budget appropriations and expenditure.

MTN ACQUISITION OF IHS HOLDING

- **South Africa's Competition Commission Backs MTN's IHS Tower Deal, With Conditions** — TechAfrica News, 30 September 2026

  Trade-press account of the Competition Commission's conditional recommendation on MTN's purchase of IHS, summarised under the Commission's own statement.

- **Statement on the Latest Decisions by the Competition Commission** — Competition Commission South Africa, 30 September 2026

  South Africa's Competition Commission recommended that the Tribunal approve MTN's acquisition of tower operator IHS, on conditions of fair and non-discriminatory access to IHS towers for rival operators, fair lease renewals, ring-fencing of customer information and an operationally independent IHS. Job protection and ownership conditions are attached.

VODACOM WESTERN CAPE NETWORK INVESTMENT

- **Vodacom Western Cape Invests R500 Million to Expand 5G and Digital Connectivity** — Tech Africa News, 6 October 2026

  Vodacom says it is investing more than R500 million in its Western Cape network this financial year. About R380 million goes to modernising the radio network at more than 50 sites, with 4G capacity upgrades, new 5G sites and backup power in townships including Khayelitsha, Delft and Mitchells Plain.

LEO SATELLITE LICENSING FRAMEWORK

- **Regulators must know when not to regulate – ICASA chairperson** — Connecting Africa, 8 October 2026

  ICASA's chairperson said the regulator has developed a draft satellite licensing framework and will use sandboxes and lighter-touch approaches beside licensing. He named data centres and cloud computing as infrastructure it must now address.

SATELLITE MARKET ENTRY VIA SECTION 13

- **Starlink rival maps out SA strategy beyond satellite broadband** — ITWeb South Africa, 8 October 2026

  Amazon Leo said it has applied for licences to bring a direct-to-device satellite service to South Africa with mobile operators, probably from around 2028. Its fixed satellite broadband is to be distributed by Herotel from 2027.

GOVERNMENT NETWORK SITE SPEEDS

- **South Africa Wants a Digital Government. Some Government Offices Still Have Copper Internet. | Apples and Oranges** — Apples and Oranges, 11 October 2026

  South Africa's Auditor-General found that 2,076 of about 7,800 sites on the state IT agency's network ran below 10Mbps and that 294 government facilities were still on copper, in its audit of the communications department for 2025/26. The state broadband programme also fell short of its target of 14,742 sites for the year.

UPPER 6GHZ 5G-ADVANCED TRIAL

- **MTN SA trials Africa's first 5G-U6GHz network** — ITWeb Africa, 13 October 2026

  MTN South Africa said it had completed a 5G-Advanced trial in the upper 6GHz band at its headquarters, under a temporary licence, reaching peak downloads of 10.35 gigabits a second. The regulator's 2026 frequency plan allocates the band to mobile, but it is not yet licensed commercially.

PUBLIC SERVICE INSTITUTIONS CONNECTED UNDER THE 2022 SPECTRUM-LICENCE OBLIGATIONS

- **Media Statement: Committee Concerned as Public Service Institution Connectivity Reaches Only 49.1% of Spectrum Obligation Target** — Parliament of South Africa, 14 October 2026

  South Africa's mobile operators had connected 10,851 of the 21,878 public service institutions required under their 2022 spectrum licence obligations, 49.1%, by March 2026, the regulator ICASA told Parliament's communications committee on 14 October 2026. Vodacom, Telkom and Liquid met the 65% minimum threshold; MTN and Rain did not.

Data Storage

JOHANNESBURG DATA-CENTRE EXPANSION

- **Equinix points to data centres' economic role amid resource concerns** — Business Day, 3 September 2026

  Equinix said its South African build-out runs to about 160MW of added capacity under a R7.5bn investment programme, including two proposed Cape Town facilities approved for land-use changes in July 2026. The South African Human Rights Commission called for submissions in May on data centres' resource use, and Eskom expects a 2-3GW generation surplus. No date is given for the R7.5bn programme.

HUMAN RIGHTS COMMISSION INQUIRY INTO DATA CENTRES

- **Civil society groups in South Africa call for temporary halt to new data centres** — Africanews (AP), 4 September 2026

  South African civil society groups called on 4 September 2026 for a halt to new data centres until their use of water, land and electricity has been investigated. The South African Human Rights Commission has received over 250 submissions since May 2026. The main point of contention is a municipal approval for an Equinix hyperscale facility in Cape Town estimated to need 160 megawatts.

PUBLIC PARTICIPATION IN DATA-CENTRE APPROVALS

- **Civil society groups in South Africa call for temporary halt to new data centres** — Africanews (AP), 4 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

WATER AND POWER CONSTRAINT ON THE DATA CENTRE PIPELINE

- **SA's data centre boom risks hitting a wall over water and power** — Sunday Times (TimesLIVE), 8 September 2026

  A ratings agency rates South Africa's water resilience relatively low and names energy and water as the risks to a data-centre pipeline, suggesting operators may need modular energy that bypasses the grid.

AWS AFRICA (CAPE TOWN) REGION

- **AWS puts $2.3bn behind Africa's cloud, AI future** — ITWeb South Africa, 10 September 2026 AFRICA

  A large cloud provider says it has invested more than US$819 million in African infrastructure since 2018 and committed a further US$1.5 billion to 2029, with 154 services now available in its Cape Town region. Its general manager for Sub-Saharan Africa told a Johannesburg summit the Africa strategy is increasingly aimed at local developers building for regional markets, and claimed more than a million Africans trained in cloud and AI skills.

JNB11 DATA CENTRE OWNERSHIP, CENTURION

- **Merger Alert: Competition Tribunal approves acquisition of JNB11 data centre; and renewable energy merger with HDP ownership conditions** — Competition Tribunal of South Africa, 16 September 2026

  South Africa's Competition Tribunal approved the acquisition of the JNB11 data centre by Main Street 2156, a newly formed South African company, from Vantage Data Centers South Africa. The deal transfers the companies that operate the facility and own its building and lease rights. The notice gives no transaction value, conditions or ultimate buyer.

- **South Africa could soon get a new fibre giant as rivals plot major merger** — African Insider, 18 September 2026

  South African fibre operators Octotel and MetroFibre confirmed they are assessing a possible merger, reported on 18 September 2026. Old Mutual's African Infrastructure Investment Managers owns all of Octotel and 37% of MetroFibre; a combined network would rank third behind Vumatel and Telkom's Openserve. No deal has been finalised.

CAPE TOWN DEVELOPMENT GUIDELINES FOR LARGE DATA-CENTRE APPLICATIONS

- **Cape Town to write new rules for big data centre applications** — TechCentral, 17 September 2026

  Summarised under Connectivity.

STANDARD BANK GROUP HYBRID-CLOUD PARTNERSHIP WITH HUAWEI

- **Standard Bank Group, Huawei forge strategic cloud partnership to drive digital, intelligent finance in Africa** — ITWeb South Africa, 29 September 2026

  Standard Bank Group expanded its partnership with Huawei to move its core banking systems from legacy infrastructure to a hybrid cloud platform, in phases across the 21 African countries it operates in. No value, timetable or hosting location was given.

CONTINENT 8 DATA CENTRE, JOHANNESBURG

- **Continent 8 Technologies launches data center in Johannesburg, South Africa** — Data Center Dynamics, 5 October 2026

  Continent 8 Technologies, which hosts online gaming and betting operators, announced its first African data centre, in Johannesburg. It did not disclose the site or any colocation partner.

Energy

STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK FOR OFFSHORE WIND DEVELOPMENT

- **A Strategic Framework for Offshore Wind Development in South Africa** — World Bank / ESMAP, 10 September 2026

  The World Bank published a strategic framework for offshore wind in South Africa, prepared by the Carbon Trust with the Department of Electricity and Energy and funded by ESMAP, posted on 10 September 2026. It estimates about 95 GW of technical potential along the 2,800 km coastline and notes that rules on site exclusivity and seabed leasing have not been enacted.

- **South Africa sees offshore wind powering AI data centres** — TechCentral, 17 September 2026

  South Africa's electricity and energy department published a strategic framework for offshore wind, identifying about 95GW of technical potential along the coastline and naming energy-hungry coastal users, data centres among them, as the customers who could justify building it. The laws and regulations the build would need do not yet exist and the costs are large.

Technical Capacity

ACTIVE .ZA DOMAIN REGISTRATIONS

- **ZARC reaches 1.5m active .ZA domains** — ITWeb South Africa, 5 October 2026

  South Africa's domain registry reports 1.5 million active registrations across its four commercial second-level namespaces. It says that makes .ZA the first African country-code domain to reach the mark.

Cybersecurity

HUNGRY LION CUSTOMER CREDENTIAL EXPOSURE

- **Hungry Lion customer creds online for months** — ITWeb, 1 September 2026

  Customer credentials for the fast-food chain Hungry Lion were exposed for about nine months through its consumer-facing web portals, on analysis of stealer-log data finding 23 records tied to its South African domain, 13 of them customer accounts.

BULK WATER UTILITY CYBER SECURITY INCIDENT

- **Hackers breach Rand Water's defences** — ITWeb South Africa, 4 September 2026

  Rand Water, Africa's largest bulk water utility and supplier to more than 16 million people, disclosed a cyber security incident on 3 September and is operating from its Centurion disaster-recovery site while it establishes the extent of the damage. Its debt officer said intruders reached some servers at night before IT staff could block them and that some servers were damaged; water treatment, quality control and bulk supply are stated to remain fully operational.

THIRD-PARTY SERVICE PROVIDER BREACHES AFFECTING A TELECOM OPERATOR, AN INVESTMENT PLATFORM, A BANK AND A FINANCIAL SERVICES GROUP

- **SA's Cell C, EasyEquities and Bidvest Bank warn customers of data leak** — Connecting Africa, 14 September 2026

Cell C, EasyEquities and Bidvest Bank notified South African customers of a breach at an unnamed third-party provider, reported on 9 September. Cell C Fiber customers' names, emails, numbers and account numbers were exposed; Bidvest Bank's exposure awaits a forensic investigation.

- **Third-party cyber breaches rock SA firms** — ITWeb South Africa, 17 September 2026

  Four South African financial and telecommunications names disclosed customer-data exposure that began at third-party suppliers rather than in their own systems, and a separate supplier breach is said to have compromised information held for about 45 insurers. One financial services group suspended data sharing with its screening supplier and reinstated the service only after forensic sign-off and credential replacement.

COMMERCIAL SECURITY OPERATIONS CENTRE, CAPE TOWN

- **Integrity360 invests R55m in CT base and its largest SOC** — ITWeb South Africa, 15 September 2026

  A 40-desk security operations centre opened in Cape Town on 14 September under a R55m investment, providing monitoring and incident response for customers across Africa and internationally, and stated to create about 100 jobs over three years.

MIP HOLDINGS INSURANCE-TECHNOLOGY BREACH

- **Hollard rejects hacking claim, points to MIP cyber breach** — ITWeb South Africa, 16 September 2026

  An extortion attack on insurance technology provider MIP Holdings, detected on 14 June 2026, exposed personal data linked to customers of about 45 South African insurers. Hollard said a ransomware group's claim against it traced to that incident, not to its own systems.

- **Hackers turn on insurers after MIP paid the ransom** — TechCentral, 18 September 2026

  The group behind the June breach at an insurance software supplier is now extorting South African insurers directly, after the supplier paid a ransom for an undertaking to destroy the data. Material on a leak site includes policyholders' names, their children's names, identity numbers and email addresses; about 45 insurers' customers were exposed.

- **Hollard data hits dark web after MIP hack** — ITWeb South Africa, 18 September 2026

  Data allegedly stolen from a South African insurer appeared on the dark web, a researcher confirming it is public, after the June attack on its software supplier. The criminal group had demanded a ransom from the insurer to keep it private.

SUSPECTED BREACH OF THE ENATIS VEHICLE DATABASE

- **Inside the fake AARTO fine scam** — ITWeb South Africa, 18 September 2026

  South Africa's road traffic infringement agency is considering an investigation into whether the national vehicle database was accessed, after fake traffic-fine messages began quoting motorists' correct number plates. The fines platform being impersonated says its own system was not breached.

GAUTENG E-PANIC BUTTON APP DATA EXPOSURE

- **Gauteng panic app exposed crime reports and your locations** — GroundUp, 23 September 2026

  GroundUp reported on 23 September 2026 that the database behind the Gauteng Department of e-Government's e-Panic Button app was unsecured, exposing users' names, crime reports with images, GPS location histories and login PINs. Contractor Evolve VAS, which holds a R10 million contract, fixed the flaws after GroundUp's alert on 21 September; the provincial government did not respond.

- **Gauteng spending R269 million for app downloaded 15,000 times in 10 months** — MyBroadband, 25 September 2026

  Gauteng's Department of e-Government said in replies to DA questions, reported on 25 September 2026, that its e-Panic Button contract with Evolve Value Added Services is worth R269 million in total and runs to 10 March 2027. It has paid R131.3 million over three years, and the app gained only 15,000 new downloads between October 2025 and August 2026, out of more than 180,000 overall.

- **DA to report e-Panic button data breach to Information Regulator of South Africa** — Democratic Alliance Gauteng, 28 September 2026

  South Africa's opposition DA in Gauteng will ask the Information Regulator to investigate the exposure of data from the provincial e-Panic Button app, including crime reporters' names, reports, photos and locations. It says the department did not inform the legislature's oversight committee.

- **DA to report e-Panic data breach to Information Regulator** — GroundUp, 28 September 2026

  South Africa's Democratic Alliance said it will report a data breach in the Gauteng government's e-Panic Button app to the Information Regulator, reported on 28 September 2026. An unsecured database exposed crime reports with the names, phone numbers and locations of those who filed them. Nearly a week after the disclosure, the province had not commented or told affected users; the contract is reported at R269m.

- **Gauteng e-government assures panic button app data is secure despite security breach** — The Citizen, 29 September 2026

  Gauteng's e-government department said the flaw in its e-Panic Button app is patched and no personal data was compromised, and put active users at 288,307. The student who reported the flaw disputes that account, saying ID numbers, addresses and crime details were exposed unencrypted.

- **Information Regulator to engage Gauteng over e-Panic Button data breach** — Mail & Guardian, 30 September 2026

  South Africa's Information Regulator said it had received no breach notification from Gauteng's e-government department over the exposed e-Panic Button database and would engage the department, noting it can issue an information notice.

- **e-Panic Button security flaw sparks legislature probe** — ITWeb South Africa, 1 October 2026

  A Gauteng legislature committee said it will examine whether the provincial e-government department's earlier assurances about the e-Panic Button's security were accurate. The department says an attempted breach was identified and fixed and that no personal information was compromised.

- **Gauteng committee demands answers after e-Panic Button app data breach sparks outrage** — The Citizen (South Africa), 1 October 2026

  The Gauteng legislature's e-government committee rejected the provincial department's assurance that no personal information was compromised by the e-Panic Button exposure, and gave it seven days to report. It wants an incident timeline, proof of notification to the Information Regulator and residents, and the contract's data-protection clauses.

- **ACCOUNTABILITY OVER ALLEGED E-PANIC BUTTON SECURITY BREACH - Yo School Mag** — Yo School Mag, 8 October 2026

Gauteng legislature committees said after a joint meeting on 5 October 2026 that the provincial Department of e-Government notified the Information Regulator of the e-Panic Button data exposure only that morning, about two weeks after being alerted on 21 September. The department could not say how many records were exposed, and the committees demanded an investigation independent of the app's service provider.

CYBER CRIME VICTIM HELPLINE PILOT

- **Free cyber crime victim helpline launches** — ITWeb South Africa, 14 October 2026

  MiDO Academy and the UK charity The Cyber Helpline, funded by Amazon Web Services, began a 12-month pilot of a free, 24-hour cyber crime victim helpline in South Africa for anyone aged 13 or over. Supervised MiDO students answer calls and refer victims to banks, the police and mental health services.

PAYMENT SYSTEM CYBERSECURITY AND CYBER-RESILIENCE DIRECTIVE (DIRECTIVE 1 OF 2024)

- **Regulation (National Payment System Department)** — South African Reserve Bank, 17 October 2026

  The South African Reserve Bank explains how its National Payment System Department regulates the payment system for safety, efficiency and stability, including the prevention of fraud and money laundering. It says consumer protection in payments is the job of the Financial Sector Conduct Authority.

DPI

Data Exchange · Digital Identity and CRVS · Digital Payments and Fintech · Registries · Sectoral management information systems · Other GovTech and e-Gov

Data Exchange

CUSTOMS-TO-CUSTOMS DATA EXCHANGE

- **Five Southern African countries move to link customs data as trade corridors face pressure to cut delays** — Southern African Times, 2 September 2026 ZAMBIA MALAWI MOZAMBIQUE ZIMBABWE SOUTHERN AFRICA

  Customs administrations of Malawi, Mozambique, South Africa, Zambia and Zimbabwe adopted a roadmap and action plan for customs-to-customs data exchange at a meeting in Pretoria on 24-26 August 2026, hosted by the South African Revenue Service and convened by TradeMark Africa. The aim is to share trade data before consignments reach the border, building on existing Zambia-Malawi and Zambia-Zimbabwe links.

DIGITAL VAT MODEL

- **VAT Connect Issue 21 (September 2026)** — South African Revenue Service, 8 September 2026

  The South African Revenue Service confirmed in VAT Connect Issue 21 on 8 September 2026 that the VAT Act now defines e-invoice, e-credit note, e-debit note, interoperability framework and e-reporting, in force from 1 April 2026 under the Tax Administration Laws Amendment Act 4 of 2026. The finance minister may prescribe a voluntary e-reporting system by regulation. No commencement date for those regulations is given.

ONE-STOP BORDER POSTS AND DIGITISED BORDER SYSTEMS

- **Lesotho-South Africa Bi-National Commission (BNC) Mid-term Review Concludes in Pretoria** — Government of Lesotho (via APO Group), 10 September 2026 LESOTHO

  Lesotho and South Africa concluded a mid-term review of their Bi-National Commission in Pretoria on 9 September 2026 after three days of talks. Outcomes included faster work on Smart One-Stop Border Posts at Maseru and Ficksburg, progress on a new migration model for labour mobility, and Phase II of the Lesotho Highlands Water Project. The next full session is set for South Africa in 2027.

HOME AFFAIRS AND ELECTORAL COMMISSION IDENTITY VERIFICATION INTERFACE

- **Home affairs investigating 21 cases of identity theft and fraudulent IDs** — TimesLIVE (Sunday Times), 23 September 2026

  South Africa's home affairs minister Leon Schreiber said in a parliamentary reply that the department is investigating 21 cases of identity theft and fraudulently obtained identity documents. Suspect documents are flagged through the HANIS and ABIS biometric systems and checks against the National Population Register, and officials found to have helped will face disciplinary action.

Digital Identity and CRVS

INVESTIGATION INTO VISA ADJUDICATION WITHOUT VERIFICATION

- **Home Affairs officials 'paid to ignore' fraudulent visa documents** — IOL / The Star, 4 September 2026

  South Africa's Special Investigating Unit found Home Affairs adjudicators took kickbacks to approve visas on fraudulent supporting documents without conducting any verification. It has flagged 205 visas for revocation and deportation with seven disciplinary referrals, under a 2024 proclamation covering almost two decades of visa administration, and recommends reducing human intervention through technology and integrating departmental systems so verifications run automatically.

STATE PUBLIC KEY INFRASTRUCTURE FOR DIGITAL IDENTITY

- **South Africa is behind its neighbours on the plumbing of digital IDs** — TechCentral, 11 September 2026

  Zambia's ICT regulator ZICTA completed a key ceremony establishing a national root certification authority, eight days after Namibia's regulator CRAN launched its DigiNam public key infrastructure on 31 August 2026. South Africa has no state system deployed; three private providers are accredited, and Home Affairs plans infrastructure hosted at SARS by 31 March 2027 and roll-out in 2027/28.

IDENTITY THEFT AND FRAUDULENT IDENTITY DOCUMENT INVESTIGATIONS

- **Home affairs investigating 21 cases of identity theft and fraudulent IDs** — TimesLIVE (Sunday Times), 23 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Exchange.

NATIONAL DIGITAL IDENTITY (CREDENTIAL AND WALLET)

- **End of the line: Here's when the old SA green ID book will be discontinued** — The Citizen (South Africa), 1 October 2026

  South Africa's home affairs minister said production of the green ID book will end on 31 March 2027. He showed the first working digital identity credential and put smart ID replacements at more than 515 bank branches and 822,000 users.

- **SA: Dr Leon Schreiber: Address by Minister of Home Affairs, at the Home Affairs Quantum Leap: A Vision for the Future of Government at Constitution Hill (01/10/2026)** — Polity, 2 October 2026

  South Africa's Home Affairs Minister Leon Schreiber announced at Constitution Hill on 1 October 2026 that the department will stop producing the green ID book by 31 March 2027, and that it will cease to be valid identification on 31 March 2028. The 14.7 million people who hold only a green ID book will have 12 months after production ends to switch to the Smart ID card.

- **Problem with plan for digital IDs in South Africa** — MyBroadband, 6 October 2026

  Summarised under Legislation and regulation.

ELECTRONIC TRAVEL AUTHORISATION

- **Machine learning gets first say on who gets into SA** — ITWeb South Africa, 2 October 2026

  South Africa's home affairs department said its Electronic Travel Authorisation uses machine learning to make automated, risk-based decisions on short-stay visa applications, with a human brought in where the system flags an anomaly. The system is live at four airports.

DIGITAL DRIVING LICENCE

- **Media Statement: Select Committee Briefed on Proposed Amendments to Regulations Governing Driving Licences** — Parliament of South Africa, 6 October 2026

  South Africa's Department of Transport told Parliament's Select Committee on Public Infrastructure on 6 October 2026 that draft regulations would extend light-vehicle driving licence cards from five to ten years, because of card-production delays and printer breakdowns. A Presidency-led working group with the Road Traffic Management Corporation and Home Affairs is exploring digital licences linked to the government's digital identity framework.

DRAFT REGULATIONS EXTENDING DRIVING LICENCE CARD VALIDITY TO TEN YEARS

- **Media Statement: Select Committee Briefed on Proposed Amendments to Regulations Governing Driving Licences** — Parliament of South Africa, 6 October 2026

  Summarised under Digital Identity and CRVS.

ROAD TRAFFIC REGULATIONS AMENDMENT ON ACCEPTABLE IDENTIFICATION

- **Proposed changes to Traffic Regulations to affect South Africans and foreigners** — The Citizen (South Africa), 10 October 2026

  South Africa's Department of Transport plans to amend the National Road Traffic Regulations so that Traffic Register Number certificates and learner's and driving licences can no longer be used as general identification. A 2023 check with Home Affairs of 1,072,258 TRNs found only 29,653 (2.7%) matched the national immigration identification system. The draft is to be published for 30 days' comment.

- **Department to scrap use of drivers' licences as ID** — eNCA, 11 October 2026

  South Africa's transport minister said 300,000 dormant traffic register numbers have been blocked, about half of those found to be fraudulent. Holders of the rest have been asked to verify their details with Home Affairs, and about 8,000 have come forward.

- **Government to amend regulations to prevent traffic documents being used as identification** — SAnews (South African Government News Agency), 11 October 2026

  South Africa's transport department plans to amend the road traffic regulations so that traffic register number certificates, learner's licences and driving licences no longer count as identification. A traffic register number would be valid only as long as the passport and permit it was issued on, and the draft is to be gazetted for 30 days of comment.

Digital Payments and Fintech

RETAIL ACQUISITION OF AN INFORMAL-TRADE PAYMENTS NETWORK

- **R&A Cellular deal closes: Shoprite takes 51% stake** — TechCentral, 1 September 2026

The group's results disclose that the R&A Cellular acquisition closed with effect from 14 August 2026 and that the initial stake is 51%. Financial terms remain undisclosed and the initial accounting for the combination is incomplete.

- **Shoprite targets informal retail with fintech expansion** — ITWeb, 1 September 2026

  Shoprite finalised the acquisition of an initial 51% of R&A Cellular, whose point-of-sale platform is used by informal retailers to sell prepaid airtime, electricity, gaming and entertainment — extending the retailer's financial services into South Africa's informal economy.

DIGITAL-ONLY BANK RESULTS

- **Discovery Bank hits R370m profit, clients near 2m** — ITWeb South Africa, 4 September 2026

  Discovery Bank, South Africa's digital-only bank, reported a R370 million normalised operating profit for the year to 30 June 2026, reversing a R68 million loss. Client numbers rose 26% to 1.57 million and revenue 31% to R3.1 billion; it targets R3 billion annual profit by 2029 and launches on 1 October the second phase of a strategy connecting the group's banking, health, insurance and investment businesses through AI-driven personalisation in one app.

PAYMENTS ECOSYSTEM MODERNISATION CREDENTIAL AND WALLET

- **South Africa is rebuilding the machinery behind its payments system** — TechCabal, 10 September 2026

  South Africa is rebuilding both the rules of participation in its payments system and the infrastructure underneath, three payments executives said at a Johannesburg roundtable. A proposed activity-based regulatory model would let non-banks and fintechs offer payment services directly rather than through a sponsoring bank, alongside richer payment data and faster cross-border rails.

PAYMENTS GROUP RETURN TO PROFIT

- **Lesaka turns first profit since its Net 1 rebrand** — ITWeb South Africa, 10 September 2026

  A South African payments group reported a net profit of R47.3 million for the year to June 2026 against a loss of R1.63 billion a year earlier. Its executive chairman called it full-year profitability for the first time since the group was created in 2022 out of a predecessor company; the results accompany a brand refresh.

CASHLESS MUNICIPAL SERVICE OFFICES, CAPE TOWN

- **Cape Town pilots 'cashless' driving licence centres** — ITWeb South Africa, 11 September 2026

  The City of Cape Town will pilot cashless payments at three of its 18 driving licence testing centres, in Brackenfell, Fish Hoek and Strand, from 1 October 2026. Mayoral committee member JP Smith said the pilot will test feasibility across all centres. The city began cashless payments at its customer interaction centres and vehicle licensing offices in July.

ZARP RAND STABLECOIN

- **Local stablecoins are great, but who really needs them?** — TechCabal, 21 September 2026 NIGERIA TANZANIA KENYA AFRICA

  An analysis arguing that stablecoins tied to African currencies have a weak case for retail use, because mobile money and bank transfers already work at home. It sees more promise in wholesale use and currency exchange on the blockchain. It gives supply as of 21 September 2026: about R74.6 million of ZARP in circulation and more than ₦3.75 billion of cNGN.

BANK ZERO ALLIANCE-BANKING PLATFORM

- **South Africa's Bank Zero breaks even as partnerships fuel growth** — TechCabal, 22 September 2026

  App-only Bank Zero recorded its first break-even month in August 2026, five years after opening, with 275,000 direct customers and about 500,000 more through partner platforms. Its CEO put the cost of building its own platform at under R300 million, against an estimated R3 billion to buy one.

ZARU RAND-BACKED STABLECOIN

- **South Africa’s ZARU Stablecoin Goes Live on Arc With ZAR/USDC Onchain FX Pair** — Tech Africa News, 22 September 2026

  A second report of the ZARU launch on Arc adds how trades settle: the ZARU/USDC pair clears through StableFX's request-for-quote engine, with both legs settling together or not at all, which is meant to remove counterparty risk from rand foreign exchange.

- **ZARU goes live on Circle's Arc blockchain** — ITWeb South Africa, 22 September 2026

  ZAR Universal (ZARU), a rand stablecoin issued by BlockTower under a Financial Sector Conduct Authority licence, went live on Circle's Arc blockchain and opened as a founding currency pair on Circle StableFX. Each token is backed by one rand held in South Africa, with reserves managed by Sanlam Specialised Asset Management; Luno, EasyEquities and Lesaka are partners in its development.

ONSITE CARD CHECKOUT FOR SHOPIFY MERCHANTS

- **Paystack Launches South Africa's First Onsite Card Checkout for Shopify** — Tech Africa News, 25 September 2026

  Paystack introduced an onsite card checkout for Shopify merchants in South Africa, letting shoppers pay by card without leaving the merchant's checkout. It also added a Shopify integration for its in-store Paystack Terminal.

SARB INTERCHANGE DETERMINATION PROJECT

- **Payment challengers move from consultation to action with proposals for SA’s payments future** — Business & Retail Spread, 28 September 2026

  The Association of South African Payment Providers said at a Sandton briefing that it has submitted a proposal to the Reserve Bank's National Payment System Department on merchant acceptance and interoperability for the PayShap instant payment system. It said the Reserve Bank has confirmed the association's interchange papers are being considered in its Interchange Determination Project.

TRANSFER OF PASA'S PAYMENT-SYSTEM FUNCTIONS TO THE SARB AND PAYINC

- **Payment challengers move from consultation to action with proposals for SA’s payments future** — Business & Retail Spread, 28 September 2026

  Summarised under Digital Payments and Fintech.

ABSA DIGITAL ASSET CUSTODY

- **Absa sets digital asset custody milestone** — ITWeb Africa, 30 September 2026

  Absa launched institutional digital-asset custody for South African clients on 21 September on Ripple's technology, the first such service by an African bank. It is for institutional and large corporate clients, not retail crypto.

WISE FOREIGN EXCHANGE AUTHORISATION

- **Afrique du Sud : la société financière Wise agréée par la Banque centrale** — wearetech.africa, 16 October 2026

  UK money-transfer firm Wise has received category 2 authorisation from the South African Reserve Bank to deal in foreign exchange and send money abroad under regulation. The approval date is not given; Wise already partners with Capitec.

COMMON MONETARY AREA LOW-VALUE CROSS-BORDER EFT DIRECTIVE (DIRECTIVE 1 OF 2025)

- **Regulation (National Payment System Department)** — South African Reserve Bank, 17 October 2026

  Summarised under Cybersecurity.

DRAFT DIRECTIVE ON PAYMENTS TO OFFSHORE MERCHANTS

- **Regulation (National Payment System Department)** — South African Reserve Bank, 17 October 2026

  Summarised under Cybersecurity.

SARS TAX AND CUSTOMS PAYMENT CHANNELS

- **Guide to SARS Payment Rules** — South African Revenue Service, 17 October 2026

  South Africa's revenue service sets out the rules taxpayers must follow when paying it, by each payment channel, so that payments are allocated correctly. It warns that payments that do not follow the rules may be rejected.

Registries

BENEFICIAL OWNERSHIP DECLARATION

- **New tools from CIPC to strengthen SA's fight against money laundering, terrorist financing** — Eyewitness News, 29 September 2026

  South Africa's Companies and Intellectual Property Commission launched an upgraded beneficial ownership module on 29 September 2026 that gives law enforcement agencies, including the police, the Investigating Directorate Against Corruption, the SIU and the NPA, real-time access to company ownership data. It adds search and connection-mapping tools against money laundering and terrorist financing. The first version launched in April 2023.

KWAZULU-NATAL PUBLIC WORKS PROPERTY FINDING PORTAL

- **KZN launches the Public Works and Infrastructure Property Finding Portal** — SAnews, 6 October 2026

  KwaZulu-Natal is launching a portal listing its public works properties, after an audit of all 10,067 assets and the release of a first batch of 81 unused buildings and land parcels. Organisations and developers can identify assets to lease or reuse, and residents can log complaints about them.

NPO REGISTRATION AND COMPLIANCE MONITORING ONLINE SYSTEM

- **DSD introduces new NPO system: here's what you need to know** — The Citizen (South Africa), 13 October 2026

  South Africa's Department of Social Development switches off its old NPO registration and reporting system on 15 October 2026, moving all non-profits to the online system introduced on 1 September 2025. The department says the platform links with CIPC, SARS and Home Affairs; manual submissions are no longer accepted.

SARS CLIENT INFORMATION SYSTEM

- **Client Information System | South African Revenue Service** — South African Revenue Service (SARS), 17 October 2026

  South Africa's revenue service says its Client Information System, introduced in 2014, lets taxpayers register for and manage all their tax and customs registrations in a single profile. SARS is now merging each client's tax, customs and excise records into one consolidated profile.

Sectoral management information systems

SOCIAL WORK INTEGRATED MANAGEMENT SYSTEM EXTERNAL REFERRAL PORTAL (WESTERN CAPE)

- **SWIMS external portal streamlines child abuse reporting** — Western Cape Government - Department of Social Development, 4 September 2026

  The Western Cape's Social Work Integrated Management System now accepts secure external reports of child abuse and neglect, identified or anonymous, from the professionals the Children's Act obliges to report - health professionals, legal practitioners, teachers, traditional leaders and religious leaders - routing them into the provincial case-management system rather than a separate channel.

NSFAS STUDENT FUNDING SYSTEM

- **Funding restored for TUT students after qualification code corrections** — SAnews, 13 September 2026

  South Africa's student aid scheme NSFAS restored funding to 182 Tshwane University of Technology students after the university corrected wrong qualification codes that had triggered defunding under the N+ rule. The corrections followed more than 300 helpdesk cases raised by Deputy Minister Yusuf Cassim's office. A further 1,212 students placed in accredited housing after the NSFAS portal closed have not had accommodation costs paid.

POLICE INCIDENT MANAGEMENT SOLUTION

- **Top ICT tenders: SITA sees activity surge** — ITWeb South Africa, 14 September 2026

  South Africa's State IT Agency placed four of the week's top ten ICT tenders, including a 36-month incident management system for the police, whose tender says it has no single integrated system for logging reported incidents. The Electoral Commission is tendering for identity governance, and the consumer commission for opt-out registry partners.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

ONLINE CANDIDATE NOMINATION SYSTEM

- **IEC shoots down ANC's glitch claims ahead of election** — TimesLIVE, 2 September 2026

  South Africa's Electoral Commission rejected claims that a system failure blocked a party's candidate submissions for the November local elections, its chief electoral officer saying the commission held no reports of a non-functional online nomination system on deadline day. More than 140,000 candidates have been nominated for about 10,500 council seats, to be scrutinised between 4 and 16 September.

- **Inaccurate and unverified ID numbers found on ANC election candidate lists** — The Citizen, 8 September 2026

  South Africa's ANC secretary-general Fikile Mbalula said on 8 September 2026 that some branch-submitted candidate lists for the local government elections carried inaccurate and unverified identity numbers. The party has opened an internal review of its nomination process, and has gone to the Electoral Court over the Electoral Commission's refusal to reopen list submissions.

- **IEC says ANC had zero system activity in two councils during alleged final-hour 'glitches'** — Daily Maverick, 11 September 2026

  South Africa's Electoral Commission told the Electoral Court on 11 September 2026 that its audit trail shows no ANC activity on the online candidate nomination system in two of the six municipalities where the party blames glitches for missing the 28 August deadline. The commission says its servers had no downtime, and that 2,274 candidates from 45 parties were captured but never submitted.

- **IEC promises glitch-free elections with faster queues** — The Citizen, 23 September 2026

  South Africa's Electoral Commission said on 23 September 2026 it has completed end-to-end testing of its results system for the 4 November elections, and parties may test it with their own experts from 5 to 12 October. Chairperson Mosotho Moepya cited reworked voter management devices after results-centre screens failed in 2024. More than 60,000 staff have been trained.

SITA PROCUREMENT FROM SMALL AND DESIGNATED SUPPLIERS

- **SITA spends big on procurement from SMMEs** — ITWeb South Africa, 3 September 2026

  South Africa's state IT procurement agency spent R183 million with small, medium and micro enterprises and designated groups between 1 April and 31 July, 49% of its available procurement spend against a 45% annual target.

BORDER MANAGEMENT AUTHORITY PORT HEALTH MANAGEMENT SYSTEM

- **BMA replaces e-mail with digital port system** — ITWeb South Africa, 15 September 2026

  South Africa's Border Management Authority launched a Port Health Management System at Durban Harbour, replacing shipping agents' e-mailed requests with online inspections, free pratique applications, endorsements, invoicing and payment. Durban is the pilot; no date is set for other ports.

SOCIAL SECURITY AGENCY MESSAGING SELF-SERVICE CHANNEL

- **Sassa takes grant services online with WhatsApp, kiosks and Wi-Fi** — The Citizen, 18 September 2026

  South Africa's social security agency set out a modernisation programme taking grant services online: applications and payment-detail changes, electronic life certification, messaging support, self-service kiosks and free Wi-Fi at its offices. Its systems are being integrated with other government institutions, which the agency says will help detect fraud and speed processing; no uptake figure is published for any of it.

DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION OF GOVERNMENT ROADMAP

- **Minister Solly Malatsi: National Digital Sovereignty Agenda** — South African Government (gov.za), 21 September 2026

  Opening GovTech 2026 in Durban on 21 September 2026, South Africa's communications minister Solly Malatsi said government digital systems are still fragmented and that the first phase of the Digital Transformation Roadmap ends in February 2027. He presented digital sovereignty as a matter of development rather than security. He also said he had discussed with Operation Vulindlela and the Digital Council making the country a hub for submarine cables and digital infrastructure.

ELECTORAL COMMISSION RESULTS SYSTEM

- **IEC promises glitch-free elections with faster queues** — The Citizen, 23 September 2026

  Summarised under Other GovTech and e-Gov.

- **Local Government Election Results System audit gets underway** — SAnews.gov.za, 6 October 2026

  South Africa's Electoral Commission opened its Election Results System, which captures and collates results and assigns seats, to audit by ICT experts from the ACDP, ANC, DA and MK Party from 5 to 12 October 2026. The commission said it had already completed an independent external audit of the system ahead of the 2026 local government elections.

SMART ID AND BANK-BRANCH CHANNEL

- **Good news for South Africans who want to get a smart ID from their bank** — MyBroadband, 27 September 2026

  South Africa's Home Affairs smart ID service is available at more than 500 bank branches: Capitec 247, Standard Bank 144, FNB 96 and Absa 15. Minister Leon Schreiber has said it will reach 750 branches, add first-time ID and passport applications and offer home delivery by the end of 2026. A deputy director-general said the green ID book will be phased out within two years; no invalidation date is set.

- **End of the line: Here's when the old SA green ID book will be discontinued** — The Citizen (South Africa), 1 October 2026

  Summarised under Digital Identity and CRVS.

- **SA: Dr Leon Schreiber: Address by Minister of Home Affairs, at the Home Affairs Quantum Leap: A Vision for the Future of Government at Constitution Hill (01/10/2026)** — Polity, 2 October 2026

  Summarised under Digital Identity and CRVS.

STRUCTURAL REVIEW TO REPURPOSE THE STATE IT AGENCY

- **State IT agency faces fork in the road on rehabilitation journey** — Daily Maverick, 28 September 2026

  South Africa's communications department has formally begun a structural review of what the State IT Agency should be responsible for, the minister said at GovTech 2026. The agency's managing director set out a move from custom development to shared platforms and the retirement of legacy systems.

STATE IT AGENCY AUDIT OUTCOME

- **Question to the Minister of Communications and Digital Technologies - NW5099** — Parliamentary Monitoring Group, 5 October 2026

  South Africa's communications minister told Parliament in a written reply that the State Information Technology Agency (SITA) moved from a qualified audit opinion in 2024/25 to an unqualified one for 2025/26, after Cabinet approved an interim board in February 2025 and a permanent board on 6 May 2026. SITA delivered 117 e-services through 35 digital products to more than 30 public bodies and met 80.66% of procurement requests on time.

GAUTENG PUBLIC-TRANSPORT OPERATING-LICENCE DIGITAL SYSTEM

- **Gauteng transport department launches digital system to tackle operating-licence backlog** — Eyewitness News, 6 October 2026

  Gauteng's transport department launched a digital system to clear its backlog of public-transport operating licences, after six to eight months of testing with e-hailing, taxi and bus operators, municipalities and law enforcement. E-hailing operators are first in line to regularise.

INTEGRATED JUSTICE SYSTEM PROGRAMME

- **R4.9bn justice system programme sinking amid governance failures** — The Citizen (South Africa), 7 October 2026

  South Africa's Auditor-General told Parliament's justice committee on 6 October 2026 that the integrated justice system programme has not achieved its aims after about R4.9bn spent over a decade, citing unclear accountability and fragmented oversight. It found cybersecurity and access control weaknesses, and only 63 of 506 planned network upgrades completed by 31 August 2026.

ASYLUM INTENTION-REGISTRATION AND APPOINTMENT SYSTEM

- **Government to seek court guidance on asylum ruling, introduce registration system** — SAnews (South African Government News Agency), 11 October 2026

  South Africa's government will ask the courts for a supervisory order on implementing the Constitutional Court's July 2026 asylum judgment. Home Affairs is to introduce an online intention-registration and appointment system by 10 November 2026, with assisted registration at Refugee Reception Offices.

- **Home Affairs to digitise asylum applications to speed up processing** — SAnews (South African Government News Agency), 11 October 2026

  South Africa's home affairs minister said a biometric online platform for asylum applications is to be operating by 10 November 2026, checking applicants' biometrics against earlier rejected claims and verifying their travel documents. He put the backlog of asylum appeals at about 120,000, a figure he said would be confirmed.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Digitalisation of sub-national government

GAUTENG E-GOVERNMENT DELIVERY

- **Gauteng e-Government accelerates digital transformation as e-Gov delivers more connectivity, skills and safer communities** — South African Government (Gauteng Department of e-Government), 7 September 2026

  The Gauteng provincial department's 2025/26 annual report records 96 public Wi-Fi hotspots offering up to 500MB of free internet a day, 33 e-services live, 99% provincial network uptime and 7,271 cameras on the provincial safety network. The figures are the department's own, with no audited outturn or prior-year comparison in the account.

PROVINCIAL CAMERA ESTATE AND ITS USE BY POLICE

- **Thousands of cameras to help catch Ekurhuleni killer** — ITWeb South Africa, 17 September 2026

  Gauteng's e-government department offered its camera networks to the police investigation into nine women's bodies found in Ekurhuleni since July, for detection, investigation and intelligence gathering. The department had access to 7,271 privately operated cameras in 2025/26 and a cumulative 960 of its own, and is reported to have spent R124 million on closed-circuit television.

JOHANNESBURG FREE PUBLIC WI-FI NETWORK (METROPOLITAN TECH COMPANY)

- **Joburg's Wi-Fi plan falters amid litany of woes** — TimesLIVE (Sunday Times), 20 September 2026

  Johannesburg's city-owned Metropolitan Tech Company says in its 2026/27 business plan that it is under-capacitated, with 26 network staff maintaining 1,200km of fibre. The plan budgets about R570m for operations but R20.7m for capital spending, and says more than 60% of its city subsidy services a shareholder loan. Its free Wi-Fi target for 2026/27 is 200,000 connections, against 1,574,979 recorded in 2024/25.

TSHWANE ENTERPRISE DATA AND ANALYTICS PLATFORM

- **Tshwane promises faster service delivery responses, but keeps war room dashboard internal** — Gauteng News, 29 September 2026

  The City of Tshwane and the CSIR launched an Enterprise Data and Analytics Platform on 29 September 2026, bringing municipal departments' service-delivery data into one system after a six-month test. The city's live Service Delivery War Room dashboard will stay internal; a public dashboard will be considered only once the data is fully tested.

- **Tshwane launches data platform with CSIR to boost service delivery** — The Citizen, 2 October 2026

  South Africa's City of Tshwane launched an Enterprise Data and Analytics Platform with the Council for Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR) to support its Service Delivery War Room. It follows a memorandum of understanding signed in June 2023 and a collaboration agreement of August 2026 covering July 2026 to June 2028, during which the platform is to extend to all seven regions. No cost is given.

CITY POWER PREPAID PURCHASE MONITORING PLATFORM

- **City Power's electricity theft crackdown faces data problem** — ITWeb South Africa, 16 October 2026

  Johannesburg utility City Power has put out a tender for near-real-time monitoring of prepaid electricity purchases, aimed at non-technical losses of R3.96bn in 2024/25, or 20.85% of electricity bought. Bidders may propose AI for theft prediction and customer risk scoring, but outputs must be explainable, auditable and compliant with POPIA, with humans making decisions and the data staying City Power's. Experts quoted say prepaid meters show token sales, not consumption, which limits what monitoring can find.

Technology

AI · ICT Industry · Innovation ecosystem

AI

POLICE IMPERSONATION OFFENCE APPLIED TO AI-GENERATED IMAGES

- **SAPS sounds alarm over AI-generated police images** — ITWeb, 7 September 2026

  Provincial police in the Free State have warned that creating and sharing artificial-intelligence face-swap images of oneself in police uniform can breach section 68 of the South African Police Service Act 68 of 1995, which makes impersonating a police official an offence. It is an existing statute asserted against a new practice, not a new rule.

PLACING ON THE AFRICA AI GOVERNANCE INDEX

- **SA has Africa's deepest AI infrastructure but lags on governance** — ITWeb South Africa, 9 September 2026

  A column by Johan Steyn on the Africa AI Governance Index, published in July by the Nairobi-based Lawyers Hub, which ranks South Africa eleventh in Africa on its capacity to govern AI, scoring 2.10 out of four against Rwanda's 3.25, Nigeria's 2.81 and Benin's 2.58 — the only three the index classifies as having established AI governance. The index scores all 54 states across eight pillars and 80 indicators per country, and finds every African sub-region scoring highest on strategy and lowest on implementation. The argument is that South Africa built the infrastructure first: its draft national AI policy was withdrawn on 26 April 2026 after several cited academic sources were found not to exist, leaving no dedicated policy until revised documents reach Cabinet in November 2026.

OPERATOR USE OF AI FOR REVENUE ASSURANCE

- **MTN turns to AI to catch gigabyte thieves** — ITWeb South Africa, 10 September 2026

  South Africa's largest mobile operator is using artificial intelligence for revenue assurance, identifying leakage where fraudsters tunnel traffic through zero-rated sites such as university websites. Its chief executive said adoption has accelerated as practical applications emerge across the business; zero-rating here dates from the pandemic response.

SARS MODERNISATION 3.0

- **SARS sets out Vision for the next Era of Tax Administration at Tax Indaba 2026** — South African Revenue Service, 14 September 2026

  South African Revenue Service Commissioner Johnstone Makhubu set out the agency's strategy at the 13th Tax Indaba in Sandton on 14 September 2026, putting trust, institutional capability, modernisation and partnership at its centre. He said consultations with taxpayers, practitioners and staff had produced four expectations: fairness, professionalism, responsiveness and partnership. No budget or timetable is given.

STATE AIRPORTS COMPANY AIRPORT 4.0 PROGRAMME

- **ACSA bets R21.7bn on metaverse, patrol robots** — ITWeb South Africa, 15 September 2026

  Airports Company South Africa's annual report sets a plan to 2031 to bring AI, connected sensors, blockchain and robotics into airport operations, from check-in and baggage handling to patrol robots and a metaverse proof of concept. The plan sits within a R21.7bn five-year capital pipeline that also covers wider modernisation.

COUNTRY-HOSTED AI COMPUTE (UNDP AI INFRASTRUCTURE ACTIVATION)

- **Local AI compute infrastructure in Africa: Lessons from six country-hosted deployments on governance and effective use** — United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), Regional Bureau for Africa, 17 September 2026 KENYA MALAWI RWANDA TOGO ZAMBIA AFRICA

  The UN Development Programme's Africa bureau published lessons on 17 September 2026 from the AI computing capacity it deployed in Kenya, Malawi, Rwanda, South Africa, Togo and Zambia. It identified 21 AI applications across the six, and found that data readiness, skills, institutional ownership and financing, not hardware, determine how far the compute is used.

FILM AND PUBLICATION BOARD DIGITISATION AND AI STRATEGY

- **FPB plans AI-powered oversight of streaming, social platforms** — ITWeb South Africa, 21 September 2026

  South Africa's Film and Publication Board has approved a strategy on digitisation and AI and plans to try generative AI for monitoring, classifying content and managing cases over the next three to five years. None of it is yet in use. Its enforcement committee fined 21 content distributors a total of R16.175 million in September 2026.

STANDARD BANK RESPONSIBLE AI APPROACH

- **Standard Bank, Stellenbosch University develop responsible AI framework** — ITWeb South Africa, 22 September 2026

  Standard Bank and Stellenbosch University's School for Data Science and Computational Thinking are developing a framework for responsible AI use in business, announced at a panel in Cape Town.

OPENSCOPES AIDDIA AI MICROSCOPY PROGRAMME

- **R101m UCT project brings AI microscopy to Africa** — ITWeb South Africa, 23 September 2026 KENYA UGANDA CÔTE D'IVOIRE

The University of Cape Town launched openScopes AIDDiA, a four-year, Wellcome Trust-funded programme worth GBP 4.4 million (about R101 million) pairing open-source microscopy with machine-learning image analysis for research on TB, malaria and other infectious diseases. Partners are KEMRI, Uganda's Mbarara University, Côte d'Ivoire's CSRS and Imperial College London.

FSCA RESPONSIBLE AI FRAMEWORK

- **FSCA builds AI guardrails as digital regulation expands** — ITWeb South Africa, 30 September 2026

  South Africa's Financial Sector Conduct Authority told Parliament's finance committee that an AI framework for responsible use is being developed, the one outstanding element of its data and technology governance principle. It issued 140 scam warnings in 2025/26, up from 107, and tripled crypto-provider inspections to 30.

EMPLOYEES BYPASSING WORKPLACE AI RESTRICTIONS

- **The biggest AI security risk may already be inside your company** — TechCabal, 6 October 2026

  Half of 903 South Africans surveyed had got round their employer's restrictions on AI tools in the past year, an Oliver Wyman partner told a cybersecurity roundtable in Johannesburg, citing a report due in November. He said 35% had seen AI-generated work passed off as human, and that consumer trust in AI rose from 11% in 2023 to 44% in 2026.

ICT Industry

ONLINE RETAIL AS A SHARE OF NATIONAL RETAIL TURNOVER

- **SA online retail to reach R159-billion in 2026** — World Wide Worx, 2 September 2026

  World Wide Worx's Online Retail in South Africa 2026 study, produced with Mastercard, Peach Payments and Ask Africa, forecasts online retail sales of about R159 billion in 2026, up 22.5%, and its first full year at 10% of national retail turnover. Takealot is used by 35.3% of online shoppers and Checkers Sixty60 by 15%.

CROSS-BORDER E-COMMERCE GROWTH AFTER THE SMALL-PARCEL CONCESSION ENDED

- **South African online shoppers prefer local to Temu, Shein** — Connecting Africa, 4 September 2026

  South African cross-border e-commerce growth fell to 7% in 2025 from an annual range of 30 to 50% before 2024, after the November 2024 removal of the small-parcel import concession put parcels under R500 on the standard 45% duty plus 15% VAT. Shein's growth slowed to 11% and Temu recorded an average monthly decline of 42%, while roughly 19 million cross-border platform orders in 2025 still made up 18.6% of South African e-commerce transactions.

- **Shein, Temu forced to rethink SA e-commerce playbook** — ITWeb South Africa, 9 September 2026

  South Africa's crackdown on low-value imports has significantly slowed cross-border e-commerce growth and pushed the two largest platforms from tax arbitrage towards local fulfilment and supply chains, on the Online Retail in South Africa study.

THE LARGEST DOMESTIC OPERATOR'S INTEREST IN THE KENYAN INCUMBENT

- **Vodacom's Safaricom deal struck down by Kenyan high court** — TechCentral, 15 September 2026 KENYA

  Kenya's High Court on 15 September 2026 declared the government's sale of a 15 per cent Safaricom stake to Vodacom's Vodafone Kenya unconstitutional and ordered the shares returned to the state. The three-judge bench found public participation inadequate and the buyer's identity concealed. The June sale raised KSh204.3 billion; Vodacom said it will appeal and seek a stay.

BANK-OPERATED MOBILE VIRTUAL NETWORK

- **The banker helping FNB Connect turn cellphones into gateways to everyday life** — TechCabal, 18 September 2026

  FNB Connect, the connectivity business of South Africa's First National Bank, recorded R28.6 billion in customer value and sales in its latest financial year, up 18%, and gross revenue of more than R3 billion, its chief executive Sashin Sookroo told TechCabal. Its mobile network data use reached about 50 petabytes, and it has about 1.02 million active SIMs.

PROPOSED OCTOTEL AND METROFIBRE MERGER

- **South Africa could soon get a new fibre giant as rivals plot major merger** — African Insider, 18 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

STANDARD BANK INVESTMENT IN OPAY

- **Standard Bank Group announces strategic investment in OPay and a partnership to advance financial services access in Africa** — Standard Bank Group, 9 October 2026 NIGERIA

  Standard Bank Group signed a subscription agreement to invest in Nigerian fintech OPay, to close with or shortly after OPay's proposed New York Stock Exchange listing, for which OPay filed with the US SEC on 9 October 2026. The two also plan to explore digital banking, merchant acquiring, lending and remittances. The release states no amount.

Innovation ecosystem

START-UP FUNDING CONDITIONS

- **South Africa's startup funding is recovering, but founders still struggle to find fit** — TechCabal, 2 September 2026

  South African startups raised $335.9 million in 2025, more than three times the $100.4 million of 2024, across 42 rounds rather than 25, with average deal size nearly doubling to $7.99 million. The recovery is uneven: only three of the 42 rounds carried a debt component, and continent-wide the first half of 2026 held roughly flat at $1.44 billion while deal count fell from 252 to 174 and early-stage startups took just $9 million against $25 million a year earlier. The argument is that the money is not absent but badly matched to stage.

INJINI SOUTHERN AFRICA AI EDTECH PROGRAMME

- **Injini lance un programme pour soutenir 12 start-up en Afrique australe** — wearetech.africa, 9 September 2026 SOUTHERN AFRICA

  The South African edtech accelerator Injini has launched an eight-month programme for twelve teams across Southern Africa building affordable AI tools adapted to local classrooms. The five strongest projects will receive seed funding at the end of it to develop their tools and test their impact with pupils and teachers; no amount is stated.

ALPHA TICKER

- **Nic Klopper lance Alpha Ticker pour financer et propulser l'IA en Afrique** — wearetech.africa, 17 September 2026

  A South African entrepreneur has launched Alpha Ticker, a vehicle combining capital deployment, an artificial-intelligence product for portfolio analysis, and a Compute Africa arm targeting data-centre, energy and connectivity infrastructure in sub-Saharan Africa. No fund size or investment has been published.

GOOGLE FOR STARTUPS ACCELERATOR: SOUTH AFRICA, 2026 COHORT

- **Introducing Our 2026 Cohort for the Google for Startups Accelerator: South Africa** — Google, 5 October 2026

  Google named 15 South African-led, revenue-generating AI startups to its 2026 Google for Startups Accelerator: South Africa on 5 October 2026, chosen from 1,057 applications. Each gets up to R1 million in equity-free funding, access to Google's AI models and cloud, and mentorship over three months ending in a December Demo Day.

Capacity

Training and skills

Training and skills

PROVINCIAL LOW-CODE SKILLS TRANSFER PROGRAMME

- **Microsoft skills training hailed as boost for Eastern Cape government** — ITWeb South Africa, 2 September 2026

  Microsoft and implementation partner NKUSI-IT Siyasebenza ran a three-day Power Apps skills-transfer programme for 20 IT specialists of the Eastern Cape Department of Cooperative Governance and Traditional Affairs, at the Steve Biko Centre in Ginsberg, Qonce, covering Power Apps, Power Automate, Power Pages and Dataverse. The partner's recommendation is a province-wide skills and adoption framework around AI and Copilot, cyber security and Azure, which is where a three-day course turns into a procurement position.

DIGITAL-SKILLS PIPELINE FROM SCHOOL TO EMPLOYMENT

- **SA is Not Future-Ready, Says Oosthuysen** — Business Explainer, 7 September 2026

  An industry argument that South Africa is not positioning itself as future-ready cites employer survey findings that about 55% of workers show little or no proficiency in mathematics or data skills, 52% of businesses find it difficult to hire anyone prepared for digital transformation and 70% rate workforce technology skills poor or very poor, against 118,500 unfilled ICT vacancies of which 36% are junior roles.

DIGITAL SKILLS IMPACT FUND

- **South Africa’s digital jobs drive faces a $152 million funding test** — TechCabal, 16 October 2026

  At the CollectiveXChange 2026 summit in Johannesburg on 15 October, The Collective X, which coordinates South Africa's National Digital Skills Plan, reported R600 million mobilised in its Digital Skills Impact Fund and 4,000 beneficiaries so far, against a target of 500,000 young people in digital jobs by 2034. Yellowwoods estimated that reaching 20,000 more by 2028 would take R2.5 billion ($152 million) from existing skills funds, money not yet secured.

Inclusion

Access to services · Digital divides

Access to services

INTERNET PRICES AGAINST HEADLINE INFLATION

- **Cost of Living Report — August 2026** — Competition Commission of South Africa, 1 September 2026

South Africa's Competition Commission published its August 2026 cost-of-living report, tracking prices of food, water, electricity, transport, internet and other essentials for the lowest-income households. Between January and July 2026, wired internet prices rose 3.5% and wireless 4.1%, against headline inflation of 3.8%; the internet figures cover fixed services only, not mobile data.

- **SA's internet costs climb, but other bills rise faster** — ITWeb, 7 September 2026

  Wired internet prices rose 3.5% and wireless 4.1% over the first half of 2026, both ahead of cumulative headline inflation of 3.8%, on the competition authority's cost-of-living report. Over the six years to July 2026 the two rose 18.6% and 6.4% against headline inflation of 36%, so the recent move reverses the longer pattern for a service the authority treats as essential.

MONEY SMART WEEK

- **Digital finance growth puts spotlight on consumer education** — ITWeb, 1 September 2026

  South Africa ran Money Smart Week from 24 to 30 August, an initiative of the committee the Treasury and the conduct authority established to co-ordinate financial literacy, as digital finance growth widens the consumer-protection question.

REGULATOR MARKET INQUIRY INTO THE AFFORDABILITY OF TELECOMMUNICATIONS SERVICES

- **Notice of intention to conduct market inquiry into the affordability of telecommunications services in South Africa - Notice 4130 of 2026** — Independent Communications Authority of South Africa (Government Gazette No. 55299), 4 September 2026

  South Africa's communications regulator ICASA gazetted Notice 4130 of 2026 on 4 September, announcing a market inquiry under section 4B of the ICASA Act into the affordability of voice and broadband for low-income households, rural communities, youth and informal workers. It will assess cost drivers and possible interventions, with a summary of findings due within 90 days of the inquiry's end.

- **South Africa's industry regulator launches market inquiries into OTT services and telecom affordability** — Broadcast Media Africa, 9 September 2026

  Summarised under Strategies, plans and policies.

- **Government Gazette No. 55476 (30 September 2026): ICASA General Notice 4180 of 2026, withdrawal of Notice 4130 (affordability inquiry), and withdrawal of Notices 4129 and 4148 (OTT inquiry)** — Independent Communications Authority of South Africa (ICASA), Government Gazette No. 55476, 30 September 2026

  Summarised under Strategies, plans and policies.

- **ICASA withdraws notices on OTT services and telecommunications affordability inquiries** — Independent Communications Authority of South Africa (ICASA), 1 October 2026

  Summarised under Strategies, plans and policies.

SASSA GRANT REVIEWS

- **Digital Profiteers (Part 3): How combating fraud in SA's digitalised grants system hurts the poor** — Daily Maverick (Open Secrets), 4 September 2026

Open Secrets published the final part of an investigation into South Africa's digitalised grants system, arguing anti-fraud effort falls on beneficiaries rather than on the private actors deducting from their grants. SASSA flagged more than 420,000 beneficiaries for review in 2025/26 claiming R1 billion saved and targets up to 350,000 in 2026/27 for R1.5 billion; the piece documents a pensioner losing R205 a month to a funeral policy he never consented to.

- **Weaknesses in Sassa payment system triggers portfolio committee concern after qualified audit | Alex News** — Alex News, 8 October 2026

  South Africa's Department of Social Development received a qualified audit opinion for 2025/26 because of weaknesses in the South African Social Security Agency's payment system, including grants paid to deceased people and government employees, Parliament's social development committee heard from the Auditor-General on 6 October 2026. Committee chair Bridget Masango called for tighter verification and controls.

- **SASSA steps up grant controls** — SAnews, 9 October 2026

  The South African Social Security Agency defended its intensified grant reviews, eLife proof-of-life certification and beneficiary biometric enrolment as fraud controls on 9 October 2026. It rejected claims that they exclude eligible people, after media reports of 2025/26 payments to ineligible recipients and a parliamentary committee hearing on 7 October.

PARLIMETER PARLIAMENTARY MONITORING PLATFORM

- **ParliMeter enters its next chapter** — MyZA, 9 September 2026

  South Africa's Parliamentary Monitoring Group took over ParliMeter, a platform tracking MP attendance, bills, committee meetings and questions to ministers, as its EU co-funded phase closed on 9 September 2026. The platform was built by the Organisation Undoing Tax Abuse, the Parliamentary Monitoring Group and OpenUp; a Cape Town event marked the handover.

PRESIDENTIAL HOTLINE

- **Mohai conducts oversight visit to Presidential Hotline Call Centre** — SAnews, 9 September 2026

  South Africa's deputy minister for planning, monitoring and evaluation, Seiso Mohai, made an oversight visit on 9 September 2026 to the Presidential Hotline call centre run by the State Information Technology Agency (SITA) in Centurion. The visit reviewed the case-management technology, escalation and resolution tracking, and scope for automation. The hotline has operated since September 2009.

MOBILE SPECIALIST REFERRAL PLATFORM, PATIENTS REFERRED

- **Afrique du Sud : la plateforme Vula franchit le cap des 3 millions de patients** — wearetech.africa, 15 September 2026

  South African referral app Vula Mobile, which connects rural health workers with specialist doctors, has passed three million patients referred. It operates in five southern African countries, which the report does not name.

SITA PERFORMANCE

- **Minister Solly Malatsi: National Digital Sovereignty Agenda** — South African Government (gov.za), 21 September 2026

  Summarised under Other GovTech and e-Gov.

- **New Sita boss vows to rebuild trust after governance failures** — Business Day, 21 September 2026

An interview with Magatho Mello, managing director of South Africa's State Information Technology Agency since April and its first permanent head since late 2023. He wants to retire old systems, build shared platforms that serve several departments, and simplify tendering for start-ups. A ministerial report in July had set out governance and procurement failures at the agency over 2020–25.

- **SITA in recovery mode, says comms minister** — ITWeb South Africa, 22 September 2026

  Communications minister Solly Malatsi told GovTech 2026 in Durban that the State IT Agency is recovering under stable leadership and must now deliver on digitising government services and ending fragmented systems. The conference ran under the theme of South African digital sovereignty.

Digital divides

ADULTS SHOPPING ONLINE

- **South Africa Online Shopping Lags Internet Access as Retail Market Targets Wider Adoption** — Tech Africa News, 21 September 2026

  The Online Retail in South Africa 2026 report finds 79.1% of adults online but only 34.2% shopping online in 2025, down from 36.6% in 2024, while online retail turnover rose to about R130 billion. The gap is widest among lower-income consumers and women. Delivery costs, weak last-mile service outside the cities and worries about payment security are named as barriers.

Data

National statistics

National statistics

NATIONAL STRATEGY FOR THE DEVELOPMENT OF STATISTICS

- **Individual consultancy to develop the National Strategy for Development of Statistics (NSDS) of South Africa - BW-SADC-563161-CS-INDV** — SADC Secretariat, 9 September 2026

  The SADC Secretariat issued a call on 9 September 2026 for an individual consultant to draft South Africa's National Strategy for the Development of Statistics over 180 days. The work is funded by a World Bank IDA grant to the Regional Statistics Project (P175731).

CENSUS 2031

- **Keynotes address by Deputy Minister in The Presidency, Nonceba Mhlauli, on the occasion of celebrating the Stats SA Census 30th Anniversary in South Africa, Isibalo House, Pretoria** — The Presidency of the Republic of South Africa, 9 October 2026

  South Africa's deputy minister in the Presidency, Nonceba Mhlauli, marked 30 years of censuses by Statistics South Africa in Pretoria, in a speech published on 9 October 2026. She said Census 2031 is already in development, called statistical independence a constitutional safeguard, and said South Africa, as chair of the SADC Statistics Council, seeks to share experience with the region.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

US / hyperscaler activities

MICROSOFT CLOUD AND AI INVESTMENT COMMITMENT

> - **Microsoft South Africa highlights six dimensions of digital sovereignty for AI Era** — Tech Review Africa, 24 September 2026
>
>   At a GovTech breakfast for senior officials, Microsoft South Africa set out six dimensions of digital sovereignty: data, control, operational, AI, resilience and assurance. It presented sovereignty as a range of controls set by workload and regulatory risk rather than a yes-or-no choice, and pointed to its two Azure regions in South Africa.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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